OPENCLASSROOMS
LOCALIZATION
ENGLISH LANGUAGE STYLE GUIDE

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INTRODUCTION: OPENCLASSROOMS' LANGUAGE, STYLE, TONE AND PEDAGOGICAL ELEMENTS

Language

All OpenClassrooms learning products (courses, Boosts, Skill Programs, etc.) use **US English** spelling and grammar conventions.

Style and Tone

OpenClassrooms' learning products aim for a friendly, informal style and conversational tone. It can be best summed up as: "Imagine one of your friends comes over, you have a cup of coffee, and then they show you how to code in Java/improve your Excel skills/speak better in public/etc."

Humor is more than welcome! (Just keep in mind the international nature of our Anglophone audience, which includes both native and non-native speakers from around the world, so hyper-specific cultural references can fall flat…)

We encourage translators to take reasonable liberties with the source material they are translating to align with this style/tone. **This is especially important for video script translation, as these scripts will be read on camera from a teleprompter.** Don't forget to read your script translation out loud to make sure it reads well.

Please aim for a style focused on accessibility, i.e., short sentences with simple structure, commonly used/non-academic vocabulary, focusing on precision and directness.

The use of either the first person inclusive ("we") or second person to address the student directly ("you") is acceptable. Please mirror the source text's use of person whenever possible.

Please feel free to localize any French personal and place names to a more international/Anglophone equivalent, depending on the specific instructions you receive for each project (for example, Angélique could become Angela and Paris, New York or London, but specific France-related case studies in a marketing course might need to remain as-is to allow the subject matter expert to make changes later.)

Active voice

Use the active voice as much as possible to preserve clarity on who is taking action.

Instead of:	**You could write:**
It is by changing core businesses…that **an organization can be radically transformed.**	It is by changing core businesses…that **we can radically transform an organization.**
Actions **can be taken** to improve conditions for all.	Each and every one of us **can act** to improve conditions for all.

However, if you are translating from a language where passive constructions are more common and thus often leave out an agent (such as French), the passive voice is acceptable if there is no feasible way to render the sentence in the active voice.

Clear, simple and concise language

Clear, simple and concise language is the easiest to understand. Try to avoid jargon whenever possible, especially in beginner-level courses. However, sometimes overly choppy sentences can render an informal, friendly text a bit curt, so there is a fine line to walk sometimes. The EU Directorate-General for Translation's Fight the Fog is an excellent guide on all things clear and concise!

Title Conventions

In accordance with OpenClassrooms' pedagogical philosophy, all learning product titles (as well as part, chapter, and section titles) should start with **an action verb in the imperative**:

Learn About Design Thinking

Prepare Your Research

Use the 5 Whys Technique

Learning product titles should not be put between quotation marks.

See **CAPITALIZATION** for further details on title capitalization conventions.

Learning Objectives

In every OpenClassrooms learning product, the **learning objectives** are found at the end of the course introduction or Skill Program/Boost landing page, after the phrase "By the end of this course/Boost/Skills Program, etc., you will be able to:".

A few examples:

OVERVIEW PROJECTS SUPPORT

We can all develop our **learning ability**.

Lifelong Learning is a short **four-week training program**, totaling 12 hours. The goal of this program is to equip you with the **techniques** and **tools** to help you optimize your learning and build your own training plan.

Training goal

This program's learning outcome is to be able to design a **personalized, optimized, and motivating plan for acquiring your targeted skills.**

By the end of this Short Boost program, you will be able to:

- identify the skills you have already acquired;
- design a plan to acquire the skills you've targeted;
- optimize your learning process;
- identify opportunities to stay motivated.

Discover how to use Facebook ads to highlight your posts, generate engagement with your target market, and optimize your budget!

Learning Outcomes

By the end of this course, you'll be able to:

- Prepare an ad campaign using advanced marketing techniques.
- Create a campaign on Facebook Ads Manager based on the desired target and budget.
- Optimize your ad campaign using monitoring and A/B testing.

Part #2 - Launch Your First Campaign

1. Prepare Your First Campaign
2. Step 1: Set Your Objective
3. Step 2: Configure the Ad Set
4. Step 3: Draft Your Ad
5. Track Conversions With the Facebook Pixel

Quiz: Launch Your First Facebook Campaign

Part #3 - Maintain Your Campaign

1. Optimize Your Campaign
2. Refine Your Audience
3. Improve Your Campaigns With A/B Testing

Quiz: Maintain Your Campaign

All learning objectives in course introductions/landing pages/as quiz titles should start with an **action verb in the imperative.** (See above examples.)

ABBREVIATIONS, ACRONYMS AND INITIALISMS

Abbreviations

Abbreviations that are not proper nouns (i.e., acronyms or initialisms) can generally be separated into two categories in English:

1. **Contractions** omit the middle of a word and leave the first and last letters. They are followed by a period in US English:
   Dr. Henry Jekyll
   Mr. Edward Hyde
   Alien vs. Predator
2. **Truncations** omit the end of the word (and sometimes other letters), and thus are followed by a period (for example, co., inc., cf., etc.) and sometimes have a period after each letter (e.g., i.e., which should both be followed by a comma).

Acronyms/Initialisms

Acronyms/initialisms that are not widely known to the general public should be expanded when they appear for the first time in a text, except those whose shortened forms are used more often in common parlance (for example, the WHO, NATO or the FDA).

Acronym expansions should be written out in the following format:

> French Agency for the Safety of Health Products (*Agence française de sécurité sanitaire des produits de santé* [ANSM]).

Acronyms should be expanded at the first instance that they appear in the text. After that, use the acronym.

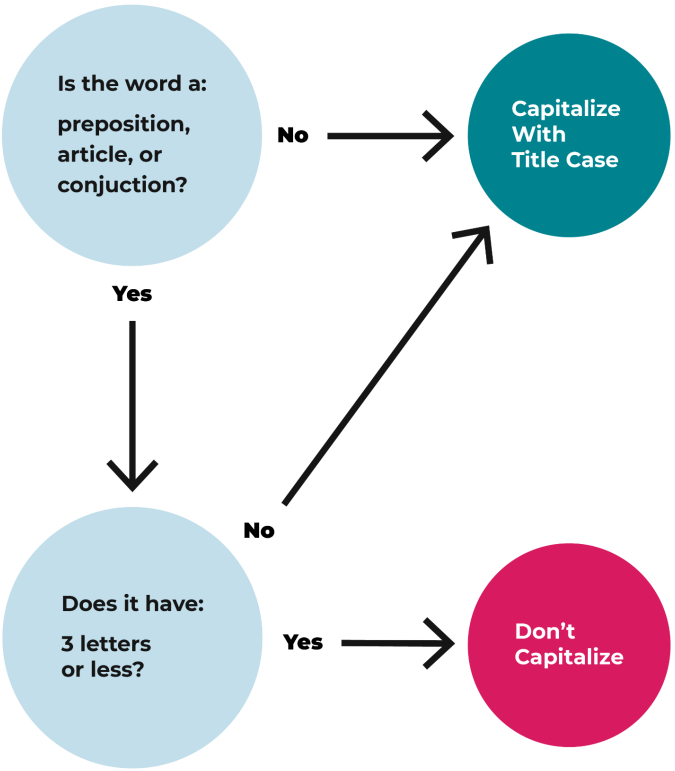
Exception: Acronyms should never be expanded in titles or headers. Use the acronym in the title or header, expand the acronym the next time it appears in the text, and then use the acronym from then on.

CAPITALIZATION

In long titles, principal words are capitalized and minor words (prepositions, articles, conjunctions) are kept in lower case. Words less than three words long are kept in lower case.

Here is a handy flowchart for title case capitalization:

Title Case Capitalization Flowchart



A few title examples:

Get the Most out of This Course

Develop Your Sense of Observation

Gather User Needs With an Empathetic Approach

Precisely Define the Problem to be Solved

CURRENCY

Please localize all currency in any OpenClassrooms project. USD ($) should be used in all EN projects. (Unless the currency is part of a formula, there's no need to do any conversions, you can just replace the currency symbol.) There should not be a space between the currency symbol and the amount.

$13,000

If the need to use any other country's currency comes up in a project, use the 3-letter currency code (https://www.iban.com/currency-codes) before the amount, with a non-breaking space in between.

JPY 800,000

Abbreviations for “million” and “billion” are as follows:

$16m

$4bn

DATE AND TIME

Use standard US date and time formats, with a non-breaking space in between the month and the date in the first format:

July 4, 1776

07/04/1776

11:30 a.m.

6:15 p.m.

FOREIGN WORDS/PHRASES IN ENGLISH

Foreign words/phrases used in English should be italicized (**not** put in quotation marks) and should always have the appropriate accents:

raison d’être

schadenfreude

hygge

Not all foreign words are italicized, as some terms are more widely used in English and written without any specific typographic conventions:

detour

per se

kindergarten

ad nauseum

Do not use italics for proper nouns, names, institutions, or places.

GENDER-NEUTRAL/INCLUSIVE LANGUAGE

Use gender-inclusive language that does not indicate a person’s gender when it is not relevant.

Instead of:	Use:
Chairman	Chairperson, Chair
Policeman	Police officer
Stewardess	Flight attendant

Do not use the generic he/his/him, or phrases such as “man” or “mankind.” Instead, you can address the reader directly (“you”) if the context allows it, use plural or neutral nouns, or use the singular generic they.

Don’t write:	Do write:
Each Board member must cast **his** vote before December 31.	Each Board member must cast **their** vote before December 31 OR **All** Board **members** must cast **their vote** before December 31
An employee can request a one-on-one meeting with **his** supervisor.	**You** can request a one-on-one meeting with **your** supervisor OR An employee can request a one-on-one meeting with **their** supervisor OR **Employees** can request a one-on-one meeting with **their** supervisor.

NAMES AND TITLES

Do not write surnames in uppercase letters.

Vermin Supreme, **not** Vermin SUPREME

Use a non-breaking space between a first name and a last name, as well as between a title and a first name.

Use “Ms.” when translating courtesy titles for women.

NUMBERS

Write out all numbers from one to nine, and use digits for numbers 10 and above, except in a numerical or bulleted list. Use a non-breaking space between a number and the word that follows it.

Use a comma as a thousand separator (1,000) and a period as a decimal point (23.17%).

For all amounts in the millions and above, use a numerical modifier with the word “million” or “billion”: 1.6 million instead of 1,600,000, unless using the numerical form aids comprehension.

PUNCTUATION

Apostrophes

All apostrophes should be curly (Alt + 146, ’). For feet and inches symbols, see **Units of measure**.

Bullet Points

Use a period after a bullet point that is a complete sentence.

Also use a period after a bullet point that completes an introductory stem. The first word of each bullet point should be lowercase to conserve the flow of the sentence:

> The approach needs to:
>
> - be human-centered.
> - be anchored in an iterative process (loop).
> - alternate phases of diverging and converging.

Do not use a period after bullet points that are not sentences and do not complete a stem:

> Which of the following are closest to the definition of a designer?
>
> - An artist
> - An ergonomist
> - An engineer
> - A problem-solver

Whenever possible, render bullet list items as either all complete sentences or completing an introductory stem, or all sentence fragments that do not require a period.

Commas

The Oxford comma should be used where it will bring clarity. Some fun real-life examples:

> We went caroling with our dogs, Grandma and Grandpa.
>
> …Merle Haggard’s two ex-wives, Kris Kristofferson and Robert Duvall.
>
> It was always difficult being Harry Potter, and it isn’t much easier now that he’s an overworked Ministry of Magic employee, a husband and father of three school-age children.

Em Dashes

In US English, em dashes are often used where en dashes would be in UK English. There should not be a space between text and an em dash.

> Grammar—which is, incidentally, neither universal nor immutable—is a feature of all languages.

Hyphens

There should not be a space between a word and a hyphen.

> The Dunning-Kruger effect
>
> $60K-$80K

Quotation Marks

Use curly double quotation marks (Alt + 147 and 148, “ ”). For quotes within quotes, use curly single quotation marks (Alt + 145 and 146, ‘ ’).

> “That’ll be all,” she said.
>
> “And then she said, ‘That’ll be all.’ The nerve!” she scoffed.

As a general rule, periods and commas go **inside** quotation marks; colons, semicolons and dashes go **outside** of them.

> Designers are on to the “nostalgia effect,” especially in the following spheres…
>
> Fashion: both fast fashion and higher-end brands incorporate and appropriate styling details from the 80s and 90s in their designs, updating them to be relevant to the “here and now.”
>
> Here are a few examples of the “nostalgia effect”:

For question marks and exclamation points, when they are part of the quoted sentence, they go **inside** quotation marks. When they apply to the sentence as a whole, they go **outside** of them.

> Try to avoid questions that start with “Do you think…?”/“Do you…?”
>
> I cringe every time I hear the word “synergy”!

When the format requires an indented quotation block (as shown in the following example), do not use quotation marks.

In fact, Facebook gives this definition of the Feed in its online training tool, Blueprint:

> *The goal of News Feed is to deliver the right content to the right people at the right time so they don't miss the stories that are important to them.*

But Facebook is not just the Feed. As you'll see in the rest of the course, Facebook's

Avoid using quotation marks for keywords, even if they are used in the source text. They should be **bolded** as a general rule.

Slashes

There should be no space between text and a slash.

Strong performance in a complicated/volatile environment.

They design an answer through iterative processes and/or testing.

UNITS OF MEASURE

Use digits for measurements of distance, temperature, volume, size, weight, etc., even if the number is less than 10. Use a non-breaking space between the number and the unit of measure (**except** for temperature and the symbols ' and ").

Do not put a period after the abbreviation of a unit of measure (**except** for inches, to avoid confusion with the preposition “in”).

13 km

6.7°C

120 lbs

6 ft (or 6' if there is a lack of space, for example on a diagram or image)

12 in. (or 12" if there is a lack of space)